

As a farmer, budding entrepreneur, and politician—he joined the BJP while still a farmer but flopped miserably in the state elections and again as an independent in the last Lok Sabha elections—he has some interesting views.

His Eureka moment comes when he moves to Bangalore, a short walk from the opulent mansion where Mallya lives, ironic since their paths would cross in ways that Gopinath never imagined. He starts his aviation venture with helicopters but it's a reality check: his file for a NOC sits on a joint secretary's table for six months. There are other realities. As he writes: "The corridors of power in Delhi are colonized by wheeler dealers, touts and fixers. They charge a professional service fee plus speed money." It takes him two years of physical and mental torment and humiliation to get his NOC.

He enjoys huge success before finding his next Eureka moment: a low cost airline. Running an Udupi hotel, he saw why the concept was so successful: no frills, self-service, quick turnaround and cheaply run. His airline would be an Udupi Hotel in the skies. The Deccan story is now part of history; the rapid expansion connecting numerous small towns and attracting first-time fliers. This was post-reform India, with the middle class boom well underway. The greater value of this book lies in its insider look at India's aviation sector, with all its flaws and egos and lobbies, cut-throat competition,

"In a sense my story is the story of the new India. The India of possibilities in spite of all her problems."

back-stabbing and poaching. Rivals undermine him in multiple ways and Deccan's fortunes nosedive. Mallya then makes Gopinath an offer he can't refuse. Deccan Airways is history.

His journey, however, is the stuff of legends, a classic Harvard Business School case study. What makes it more appealing is the turbocharged pace at which he has lived his entrepreneurial life, an emotional, financial and physical roller coaster ride that reveals much about how a crucial industry operates and the major players in it, not just the Mallyas and Goyals but people like Branson and other global aviation legends. The Gopinath story doesn't end here. His wife runs TK's, a successful bakery in Bangalore and the captain plans to make it a franchise while working on his new cargo aviation project which he predicts will be even bigger than his low cost airline. He has the money he got from Mallya, Deccan is still a registered brand, his trusted personnel are still with him and reading his life story; it is clear the Deccan Odyssey is far from over. *Simply Fly* is not just a title or a catchy advertising slogan, it's his philosophy of life. ■

Whiff of Memory

A collection of essays excavates the past in Bollywood's global ambition

By Kaveree Bamzai



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For the Mumbai film industry, globalisation usually means the bhangra pockets of Southall and the dandia enclaves of New Jersey. The most global film on India originated from Channel 4, so perhaps it is about time that young Shanay Jhaveri reminded readers that India's engagement with the West had a distinctly European flavour before Bollywood discovered the hungry diaspora. The encounters range from Jean Renoir's *The River* (1951) to Ismail Merchant and James Ivory's *Shakespeare Wallah* (1965), and show how Indian modernism developed, not as a sudden, one-time market-induced phenomenon, but as a gradual dialogue bearing history's scars. The collection of essays has a wonderful whiff of memory, at the philosophical and personal level. Who can resist the scandal that was Roberto Rossellini running off with his main script collaborator, married-with-two-children Sonali Senroy Das Gupta, when he came to shoot *India: Matri Bhumi*, 1959, or the lesser known affair between Fritz Lang's ex-wife, who ended up becoming a supporter of the Third Reich, to a young Indian engineer and journalist Avi Tendulkar? And who can argue with Louis Malle's reaction to India, when he'd stayed back after a government-organised film festival to make *Phantom India*, 1969, in regarding it as a tabula rasa, where he could start from scratch? Or of Pier Paolo Pasolini's spectral incantation of India in *Notes for a Film on India*, 1968?

Outsider films have been the laboratories for masters such as Satyajit Ray, Subrata Mitra and Bansi Chandra Gupta, who worked together on *The River*. They have also been the stage for the exotic representation of India—such as Debra Paget's sizzling snake dance in Lang's *The Indian Tomb*, 1959. As the book notes, India's reactions have always been ambivalent, caught as it is, and more certainly was, between what Ray called Indian cinema's melodramatic fantasies and Hollywood's nightmarish perversions of India. But in a world where the aesthetic is dominated by Hollywood, it is an important reminder that other worlds and other ways of seeing exist. That Bollywood's Mumbai has in it the unforgettable essence of Malle's Calcutta. ■